

Spunk

Zora Neale Hurston · 1925

First published: Opportunity, Jun 1925

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Cover: Claude Monet, Springtime (1872). Public domain (Wikimedia Commons).

Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_New_Negro/Spunk (revision 15188012), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Spunk suggest about courage and cowardice?
- What does Spunk suggest about the supernatural?
- What does Spunk suggest about community gossip?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one

essay of the five

Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.

Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Spunk	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*courage and cowardice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Spunk

Author biography

Zora Neale Hurston was born in Notasulga, Alabama, on 7 January 1891 and grew up in Eatonville, Florida, one of the first incorporated all-Black towns in the United States. She studied at Howard University and at Barnard College under the anthropologist Franz Boas, collected African American folklore in the South and the Caribbean (Mules and Men, 1935), and became a central figure of the Harlem Renaissance. Their Eyes Were Watching God (1937) is her best-known story. She died in poverty in Fort Pierce, Florida, on 28 January 1960; Alice Walker's 1975 essay "In Search of Zora Neale Hurston" led to her rediscovery.

Historical and cultural context

Set in an all-Black Florida town modelled on Eatonville, where Hurston grew up; the story is told through the voices of men on a store porch.

Publication and reception, then and now

Published in Opportunity magazine in June 1925; included in The New Negro (1925).

Then: Won second prize in Opportunity's 1925 literary contest.

Now: A Harlem Renaissance classic of folk voice and community storytelling.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Spunk Banks, the strongest man in town, openly takes Lena from her husband, Joe Kanty, whom the porch men think a coward.

Main themes

- courage and manhood.
- the supernatural.
- community judgment.

Why it matters

It shows how a community's talk shapes reputation.

Spoilers · teacher only

Joe attacks Spunk and is shot; a black bobcat appears, and Spunk dies at the sawmill, saying Joe pushed him.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)

Before we open Spunk: What makes someone brave?
Prompt: Before we open Spunk: What makes someone brave?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)

dialect; folk tale; chorus.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. Zora Neale Hurston was born in Notasulga, Alabama, on 7 January 1891 and grew up in Eatonville, Florida, one of the first incorporated all-Black towns in the United States. She studied at Howard University and at Barnard College under the anthropologist Franz Boas, collected African American folklore in the South and the Caribbean (Mules and Men, 1935), and became a central figure of the Harlem Renaissance. Their Eyes Were Watching God (1937) is her best-known story. She died in poverty in Fort Pierce, Florida, on 28 January 1960; Alice Walker's 1975 essay "In Search of Zora Neale Hurston" led to her rediscovery. The world of the book. Set in an all-Black Florida town modelled on Eatonville, where Hurston grew up; the story is told through the voices of men on a store porch. Publication and reception. Published in Opportunity magazine in June 1925; included in The New Negro (1925). Then: Won second prize in Opportunity's 1925 literary contest. Now: A Harlem Renaissance classic of folk voice and community storytelling.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54). Community belief.

> *Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself (Spunk, paragraph 54)*

Think-aloud: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54). Community belief.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Spunk Banks, the strongest man in town, openly takes Lena from her husband, Joe Kanty, whom the porch men think a coward. Themes to track: courage and manhood.: the supernatural.: community judgment.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question.
Task: Set up a reading journal for Spunk: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does Spunk still matter? It shows how a community's talk shapes reputation.
Anchor question: Why might Spunk still be taught today?
Facilitation: It shows how a community's talk shapes reputation.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Was Joe brave? Answer: Yes, by attacking Spunk; the community changes its view.
Exit ticket: Was Joe brave?
Answer: Yes, by attacking Spunk; the community changes its view.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: Spunk.

Teacher notes · sources: Zora Neale Hurston Trust, "About Zora" (https://www.zoranealehurston.com/about/); Britannica, "Zora Neale Hurston" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Zora-Neale-Hurston); Zora Neale Hurston Trust (https://www.zoranealehurston.com/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Content note: violence, death. Prize details commonly cited; verify.

Lesson 2: Spunk

Focus: courage and guilt in a small community

Objective: Students will analyze how diction / vocabulary develops in “Spunk” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: CCSS RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4 · IN 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.11

Content note (adultery, killing, dialect): Sensitive content: Adultery; killing; dialect. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes adultery; killing; dialect.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”

Teacher only · spoilers

In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips about who will court Lena next.

Background: Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925).

Significance: Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to courage and manhood because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes adultery; killing; dialect.
Prompt: What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to courage and manhood because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: footstool — a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person; claimed — demanded; called for; sixteen — the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one; machinist — a worker who operates machines; accusingly — in a way that suggests someone has done wrong. "footstool": From foot + stool. "machinist": From French machiniste, from machine "machine, mechanical device", from Latin māchina, from Ancient Greek μηχανή "machine".
Words: footstool: a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person · claimed: demanded; called for · sixteen: the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one · machinist: a worker who operates machines · accusingly: in a way that suggests someone has done wrong

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925). Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices. Point of view: Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect. Dialect: Hurston, trained as an anthropologist, records the speech of rural Black Florida faithfully, treating it as a rich, expressive language rather than a joke. Supernatural: The black bob-cat that appears after Joe's death, and Spunk's claim that he was pushed at the saw, suggest Joe's spirit returning; Hurston never confirms it. Watch for the black bob-cat: Joe's returning spirit, watching Spunk.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself" (Spunk, paragraph 54). Community. That is point of view at work: Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect.

> *Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself (Spunk, paragraph 54)*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself" (Spunk, paragraph 54). Community. That is point of view at work: Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The witness admits "'twant nobody close to 'im," which makes the push either Spunk's guilty imagination or a supernatural act. Ask: How does this line connect to courage and manhood? Expected: The town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. (The death.)

> *Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im* *(Spunk, paragraph 44)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The witness admits "'twant nobody close to 'im," which makes the push either Spunk's guilty imagination or a supernatural act.
Ask: How does this line connect to courage and manhood?
Expected answer: The town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. (The death.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for point of view, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Spunk develops the idea of courage and guilt in a small community. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. When the text says "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44), it shows this directly. Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."
Task: Annotate the story for point of view, dialect (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Spunk develops the idea of courage and guilt in a small community. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. When the text says "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44), it shows this directly. Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage? Ask: did Joe's spirit kill Spunk? Then ask how the porch talk shapes what the town believes. Lena is talked about but barely speaks; ask what her silence shows.
Anchor question: What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?
Facilitation: Ask: did Joe's spirit kill Spunk? Then ask how the porch talk shapes what the town believes. Lena is talked about but barely speaks; ask what her silence shows.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. ("Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im", Spunk, paragraph 44). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. ("Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im", Spunk, paragraph 44). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes courage and guilt in a small community. Key takeaway: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect.
- **Dialect:** Hurston, trained as an anthropologist, records the speech of rural Black Florida faithfully, treating it as a rich, expressive language rather than a joke.
- **Supernatural:** The black bob-cat that appears after Joe's death, and Spunk's claim that he was pushed at the saw, suggest Joe's spirit returning; Hurston never confirms it.

Themes and how they develop

- **courage and manhood:** the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death.

Symbols and motifs

- **the black bob-cat:** Joe's returning spirit, watching Spunk.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself" (Spunk, paragraph 54) Community.
- "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44) The death.
- "How's yo' wife" (Spunk, paragraph 9) The taunt.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage.
Evidence: "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44)
Reasoning: Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
footstool (noun)	a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person	*"But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!*	"footstool": From foot + stool. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/footstool#Etymology)
claimed (verb)	demanded; called for	*Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.*	
sixteen (noun)	the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one	*The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.*	
machinist (noun)	a worker who operates machines	*The machinist come, looked it over an' said it wuz alright.*	"machinist": From French machiniste, from machine "machine, mechanical device", from Latin māchina, from Ancient Greek μηχανή "machine". (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/machinist#Etymology)
accusingly (adverb)		*The men glared at Elijah, accusingly.*	

	in a way that suggests someone has done wrong		
boisterously (adverb)	in a loud, rough, lively way	*The men laughed boisterously behind Joe's back as they watched him shamble woodward.*	
skittish (adjective)	nervous and easily frightened	*Tell yuh the truth, Ah'm a lil bit skittish.*	"skittish": Probably from skite + ish; compare skitter. (Wiktionary, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/skittish#Etymology)
loungers (noun)	people who idle about with nothing to do	*All the loungers in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.*	
nonchalance (noun)	a calm, unconcerned manner	*All the loungers in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.*	

Discussion questions

1. What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with courage and cowardice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Who is Spunk Banks? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife
2. How does Joe attack Spunk? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: With a razor
3. What animal appears after Joe's death? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A black bobcat
4. Where does Spunk die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: At the sawmill

5. What does Spunk say before he dies? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: That Joe pushed him
6. Retell the three most important events of "Spunk" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips about who will court Lena next.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "Spunk"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "Spunk" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: ""But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!" What does "footstool" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: footstool: a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person.
10. Reread: "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im." What does "claimed" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: claimed: demanded; called for.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "Spunk" suggest about courage and guilt in a small community? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.
2. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself" (Spunk, paragraph 54): Community. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins ""But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!", why might Hurston have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "Spunk", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: In an Eatonville store, men watch big Spunk Banks walk off with Lena, wife of timid Joe Kanty. Shamed, Joe attacks Spunk with a razor and is shot dead. A black bobcat haunts Spunk, who believes it is Joe. At the sawmill Spunk is pushed onto the saw and dies, saying Joe pushed him. The town gossips…

6. As the opening story, what does “Spunk” set up that the rest of Spunk will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44): The death. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “How’s yo’ wife” (Spunk, paragraph 9): The taunt. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What does it mean to have 'spunk'? Is it the same as courage?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does foreshadowing appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with courage and cowardice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54): Community. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in Opportunity in June 1925 and reprinted in Alain Locke's The New Negro (1925). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44): The death. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Hurston's early prize-winning story, built around a chorus of community voices.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the

community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “How’s yo’ wife” (Spunk, paragraph 9): The taunt. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54): Community. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Spunk” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44): The death. On point of view: Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Spunk”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “How’s yo’ wife” (Spunk, paragraph 9): The taunt. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to the supernatural: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Hurston need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54): Community. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Is the diction / vocabulary in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant

nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44): The death. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how "Spunk" treats courage and guilt in a small community with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Spunk see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: "How's yo' wife" (Spunk, paragraph 9): The taunt. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve courage and cowardice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself" (Spunk, paragraph 54): Community. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about courage and guilt in a small community? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: "Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im" (Spunk, paragraph 44): The death. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Zora Neale Hurston about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Useful evidence: "How's yo' wife" (Spunk, paragraph 9): The taunt. Theme link: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Spunk, paragraph 54: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im _____”
   Key: mahself
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Spunk, paragraph 44: “Den he claimed _____ pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im”
   Key: somebody
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Spunk say before he dies?
   A. That he is sorry
   B. That Lena is free
   C. Nothing
   D. That Joe pushed him
   Key: D (That Joe pushed him)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Joe attack Spunk?
   A. With a razor
   B. With his fists
   C. With a knife from the store
   D. With a gun
   Key: A (With a razor)
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What animal appears after Joe's death?
   A. A crow
   B. A snake
   C. A dog
   D. A black bobcat
   Key: D (A black bobcat)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The men glared at Elijah, _____.”
   Word bank: footstool, claimed, sixteen, accusingly
   Key: accusingly
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Spunk Banks?
   A. A storekeeper
   B. A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife
   C. A preacher
   D. Lena's brother
   Key: B (A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife)
8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The men laughed _____ behind Joe's back as they watched him shamble woodward.” Word bank: boisterously, claimed, sixteen, footstool
   Key: boisterously
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Spunk die?
   A. At home

B. In the store

C. In the swamp

D. At the sawmill

Key: D (At the sawmill)

10. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Tell yuh the truth, Ah’m a lil bit _____.” Word bank: sixteen, skittish, claimed, footstool

    Key: skittish

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The death.

12. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Community.

13. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Spunk”?

    A. What fifteen years of solitude teach

    B. Courage and guilt in a small community

    C. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

    D. The closing of the frontier

    Key: B (Courage and guilt in a small community)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Spunk”? Hurston, trained as an anthropologist, records the speech of rural Black Florida faithfully, treating it as a rich, expressive language rather than a joke.

    A. Dialect

    B. Plot

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Characterization

    Key: A (Dialect)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “How’s yo’ wife” (Spunk, paragraph 9). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The taunt.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how courage and manhood develops from an earlier story to “Spunk”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death.

17. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “All the _____ in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.” Word bank: footstool, claimed, loungers, sixteen

    Key: loungers

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44).

Sample answer: Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

20. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Spunk”? Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect.
    A. Diction / vocabulary
    B. Theme
    C. Personification
    D. Point of view

    Key: D (Point of view)

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: The death.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Community.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line ““But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'!”, what does “footstool” most nearly mean?
    A. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
    B. a worker who operates machines
    C. demanded; called for
    D. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person

    Key: D (a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.”, what does “sixteen” most nearly mean?
    A. a worker who operates machines
    B. demanded; called for
    C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person
    D. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

    Key: D (the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im.”, what does “claimed” most nearly mean?
    A. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one
    B. demanded; called for
    C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person

D. a worker who operates machines

Key: B (demanded; called for)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 9, 5, 3, 10, 17, 7, 4, 8, 12, 11, 13, 15, 18, 14, 19	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 2, 3, 8, 10, 9, 17, 5, 12, 13, 11, 14, 18, 20, 21, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 2, 5, 7, 3, 1, 8, 12, 13, 11, 18, 20, 15, 14, 19, 22	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 7, 10, 8, 17, 5, 12, 11, 13, 18, 14, 15, 20, 16, 21, 19	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	23, 9, 6, 3, 1, 12, 13, 11, 20, 18, 14, 15, 19, 21, 16, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	23, 3, 7, 6, 1, 12, 13, 11, 20, 14, 15, 18, 19, 21, 22, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 7, 23, 24, 10, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 20, 18, 21, 16, 19, 22	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	8, 9, 2, 10, 7, 11, 13, 12, 14, 18, 15, 20, 16, 22, 19, 21	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	5, 8, 10, 3, 9, 11, 12, 13, 20, 18, 15, 14, 16, 21, 22, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	6, 4, 3, 1, 25, 12, 13, 11, 14, 20, 15, 18, 21, 22, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Spunk,” how does Hurston show courage and guilt in a small community? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Spunk, how does Hurston develop the idea of courage and guilt in a small community? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Spunk develops the idea of courage and guilt in a small community. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of Spunk (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of courage and guilt in a small community. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what Spunk suggests about courage and guilt in a small community. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's diction / vocabulary and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Zora Neale Hurston uses diction / vocabulary in Spunk to complicate the reader's understanding of courage and guilt in a small community. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Situate Spunk within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of courage and guilt in a small community responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Read Spunk alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of courage and guilt in a small community follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Spunk and its treatment of courage and guilt in a small community. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's diction / vocabulary and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop a research argument that reads Spunk as evidence for a larger claim about courage and guilt in a small community in Spunk. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1): Develop an original argument that reads Spunk as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of courage and guilt in a small community. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Spunk.

SAT-style questions

1. *The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “sixteen” most nearly mean?

   A. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

   B. nervous and easily frightened

   C. a calm, unconcerned manner

   D. people who idle about with nothing to do

2. *“But that’s one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain’t skeered of nothin’ on God’s green footstool—nothin'! He rides that log down at saw-mill jus’ like he struts’round wid another man’s wife—jus’ don’t give a kitty. When Tes’ Miller got cut to giblets on that circle-saw, Spunk steps right up and starts ridin’. The rest of us was skeered to go near it.”*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Spunk”?

   A. A story told to protect a livelihood

B. Brotherhood against an indifferent sea

C. Moral worth found among those society rejects

D. Courage and guilt in a small community

SAT key: 1. A (the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one); 2. D (Courage and guilt in a small community)

Unit test

Spunk: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Middle School and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The men laughed _____ behind Joe's back as they watched him shamble woodward.” Word bank: boisterously, claimed, sixteen, footstool
   Key: boisterously
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Spunk, paragraph 44: “Den he claimed _____ pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im”
   Key: somebody
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does Spunk say before he dies?
   A. That he is sorry
   B. That Lena is free
   C. Nothing
   D. That Joe pushed him
   Key: D (That Joe pushed him)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “Tell yuh the truth, Ah’m a lil bit _____.” Word bank: sixteen, skittish, claimed, footstool
   Key: skittish
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “All the _____ in the store tried to walk to the door with an air of nonchalance but with small success.” Word bank: footstool, claimed, loungers, sixteen
   Key: loungers
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “The men glared at Elijah, _____.” Word bank: footstool, claimed, sixteen, accusingly
   Key: accusingly
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Spunk die?
   A. At home
   B. In the store
   C. In the swamp
   D. At the sawmill

Key: D (At the sawmill)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Spunk, paragraph 54: “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im _____”

   Key: mahself

9. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What animal appears after Joe's death?

   A. A crow

   B. A snake

   C. A dog

   D. A black bobcat

   Key: D (A black bobcat)

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Joe attack Spunk?

    A. With a razor

    B. With his fists

    C. With a knife from the store

    D. With a gun

    Key: A (With a razor)

11. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Spunk Banks?

    A. A storekeeper

    B. A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife

    C. A preacher

    D. Lena's brother

    Key: B (A big, fearless man who takes Joe's wife)

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Spunk”?

    A. What fifteen years of solitude teach

    B. Courage and guilt in a small community

    C. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

    D. The closing of the frontier

    Key: B (Courage and guilt in a small community)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Community.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The death.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “How’s yo’ wife” (Spunk, paragraph 9). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The taunt.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44).

Sample answer: Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

17. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Spunk”? Most of the story is told through the talk of men at the village store, especially Elijah Mosely; they act like a Greek chorus, judging and spreading the story, and their opinion of Joe shifts from contempt to respect.

    A. Diction / vocabulary

    B. Theme

    C. Personification

    D. Point of view

    Key: D (Point of view)

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Den he claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close to 'im” (Spunk, paragraph 44) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: The death.

19. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Spunk”? Hurston, trained as an anthropologist, records the speech of rural Black Florida faithfully, treating it as a rich, expressive language rather than a joke.

    A. Dialect

    B. Plot

    C. Hyperbole

    D. Characterization

    Key: A (Dialect)

20. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Hurston leaves the supernatural open but shows the community's belief in Joe's courage.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Spunk "claimed somebody pushed 'im but 'twant nobody close," and the speaker says "Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself."

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how courage and manhood develops from an earlier story to “Spunk”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: the town measures men by physical boldness; Joe, mocked as timid, proves his courage by attacking Spunk with a razor, and perhaps again after death.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Ah b'leeve Joe pushed 'im mahself” (Spunk, paragraph 54) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Community.

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “The machinist come, looked it over an' said it wuz alright.”, what does “machinist” most nearly mean?

    A. a worker who operates machines

    B. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

    C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person

    D. demanded; called for

    Key: A (a worker who operates machines)

24. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line "The cooling board consisted of three sixteen-inch boards on saw horses, a dingy sheet was his shroud.", what does "sixteen" most nearly mean?

    A. a worker who operates machines

    B. demanded; called for

    C. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person

    D. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

    Key: D (the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one)

25. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line ""But that's one thing Ah likes about Spunk Banks—he ain't skeered of nothin' on God's green footstool—nothin'!", what does "footstool" most nearly mean?

    A. the cardinal number that is the sum of fifteen and one

    B. a worker who operates machines

    C. demanded; called for

    D. a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person

    Key: D (a low seat or a stool to rest the feet of a seated person)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Middle School	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	1, 5, 10, 11, 3, 8, 2, 4, 7, 9, 6, 14, 12, 13, 17, 19, 15, 18	recall 11, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	5, 1, 6, 8, 10, 9, 2, 7, 11, 4, 12, 14, 13, 15, 17, 16, 20, 18	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	6, 7, 3, 4, 1, 10, 11, 8, 5, 14, 13, 12, 16, 19, 17, 15, 20, 21	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	3, 10, 2, 5, 1, 7, 11, 6, 13, 14, 12, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 18, 22	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	6, 23, 5, 24, 25, 9, 2, 12, 13, 14, 15, 19, 17, 16, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	5, 8, 3, 24, 6, 2, 1, 14, 12, 13, 19, 17, 16, 15, 18, 22, 21, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 4, 24, 9, 11, 10, 23, 12, 14, 13, 15, 17, 19, 16, 22, 21, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	9, 25, 5, 2, 10, 8, 6, 12, 13, 14, 19, 16, 17, 15, 20, 21, 22, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	1, 23, 25, 24, 6, 9, 11, 13, 12, 14, 15, 16, 19, 17, 22, 20, 21, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 24, 6, 23, 8, 11, 7, 14, 12, 13, 17, 15, 19, 16, 22, 21, 18, 20	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

Spunk: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Zora Neale Hurston develops courage and cowardice across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Spunk and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to the supernatural.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Spunk. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Spunk finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of community gossip. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Middle School 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Courage and cowardice

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about courage and cowardice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops courage and cowardice in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops courage and cowardice across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of courage and cowardice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of courage and cowardice in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of courage and cowardice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of courage and cowardice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on courage and cowardice in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on courage and cowardice in Spunk. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about courage and cowardice in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on courage and cowardice in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The supernatural

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about the supernatural. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops the supernatural in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops the supernatural across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the supernatural. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the supernatural in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the supernatural, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of the supernatural in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the supernatural in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the supernatural in Spunk. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about the supernatural in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the supernatural in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Community gossip

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Spunk teaches about community gossip. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Zora Neale Hurston develops community gossip in Spunk. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Zora Neale Hurston develops community gossip across Spunk. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Spunk (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of community gossip. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of community gossip in Spunk. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Zora Neale Hurston's choices in Spunk (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of community gossip, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Spunk's treatment of community gossip in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on community gossip in Spunk that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on community gossip in Spunk. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about community gossip in Spunk, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on community gossip in Spunk, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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